



THE GUESTS ARE HERE, SIR

THE DISCREET CHARM OF THE BOURGEOISIE / 1972

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Art-house drama

DIRECTOR

Luis Buñuel

WRITERS

**Luis Buñuel,
Jean-Claude Carrière**

STARS

Fernando Rey, Paul Frankeur, Delphine Seyrig, Bulle Ogier, Stéphane Audran, Jean-Pierre Cassel

BEFORE

1929 Luis Buñuel's first movie, *Un Chien Andalou*, a short made with Salvador Dalí, is a startling surrealist work.

1962 In Buñuel's *The Exterminating Angel*, guests are unable to leave a dinner.

AFTER

1977 Buñuel's last movie, *That Obscure Object of Desire*, is about the frustration of an aging man's desires for a young Spanish woman.

Luis Buñuel was a master of social satire and the surreal, who had been making movies for nearly half a century by the time he made *The Discreet Charm of the Bourgeoisie* (*Le charme discret de la bourgeoisie*). Buñuel took the idea for the movie from an anecdote told by his producer, Serge Silberman, about guests turning up at his home for dinner only to find his wife in her robe and no food, since he had forgotten to tell her he had invited them.

In Buñuel's earlier movie, *The Exterminating Angel* (1962), guests at a dinner party are marooned there for weeks, unable to leave without them or us ever knowing

why. In *The Discreet Charm of the Bourgeoisie*, Buñuel carries out a droll variation on the theme, as six well-to-do friends attempt to have dinner together but are continually thwarted by a brilliantly unhinged series of mishaps.

At first, the problems are mundane: the hosts were simply expecting the guests to arrive the following day. But soon, a dead body shows up to disrupt the proceedings. Thereafter, flamboyant sexual escapades and the interruption of the army on maneuvers are just some of the obstacles. The movie becomes increasingly surreal, yet shows the guests behaving as if nothing untoward is going on.



Luis Buñuel Director

Luis Buñuel was celebrated for his surreal movies, biting

social satire, and interest in religious fanaticism. He was born in Calanda, Spain, in 1900, and studied as a Jesuit before he met playwright Federico García Lorca and painter Salvador Dalí, with whom he made his first movie, *Un Chien*

Andalou, and a second, *L'Age d'Or* (1930). Buñuel moved to the US during the Spanish Civil War, then to Mexico, and finally France in 1955. He died in 1983.

Key movies

1929 *Un Chien Andalou*
1967 *Belle de Jour*
1972 *The Discreet Charm of the Bourgeoisie*